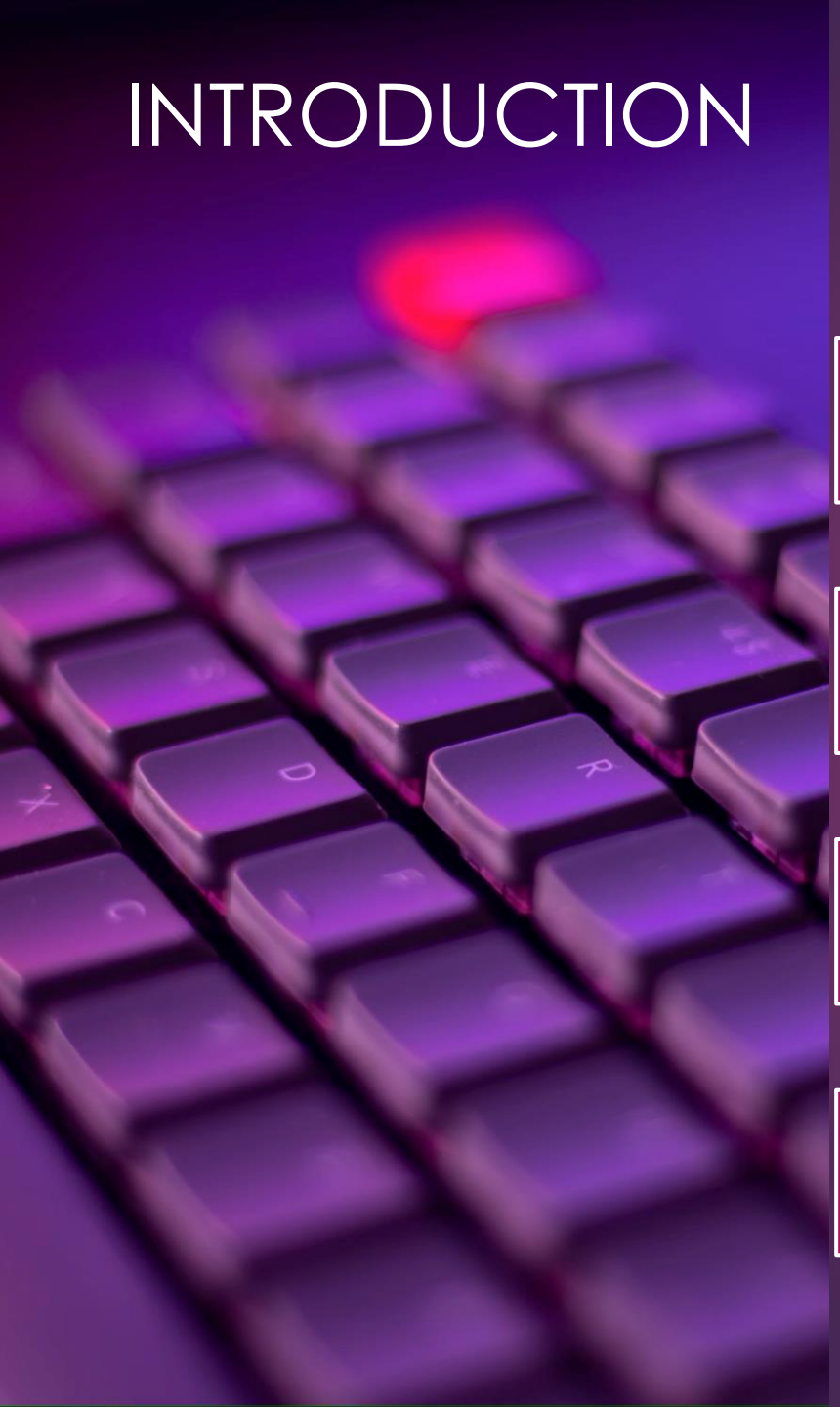
# Exploring the Career of a Penetration Tester



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# INTRODUCTION



We live in an ever-growing world, with new technologies and programs available at every turn.

With new tech and programs comes new threats and new vulnerabilities.

It takes the work of many people in different specialties to keep the digital world (and its digital citizens) safe.

This presentation will explore the specialty of penetration testing, why it is important, what skills and certifications are needed, and why I am choosing to pursue it for myself.

# WHAT IS PENETRATION TESTING?

- Also known as “pen testing”
- It is a vital part of a proactive approach to cyber security - finding the problem *before* it’s a problem
- A pen tester simulates cyber attacks to find vulnerabilities or weaknesses in a network or program
- Sometimes they determine the type and extent of damage a malicious attack could cause
- The pen tester then creates a report of everything they did and found, and provides recommendations

# SKILLS AND CERTIFICATIONS



## Hard Skills

- Cybersecurity defensive experience
- Programming knowledge
- Strong writing skills



## Soft Skills

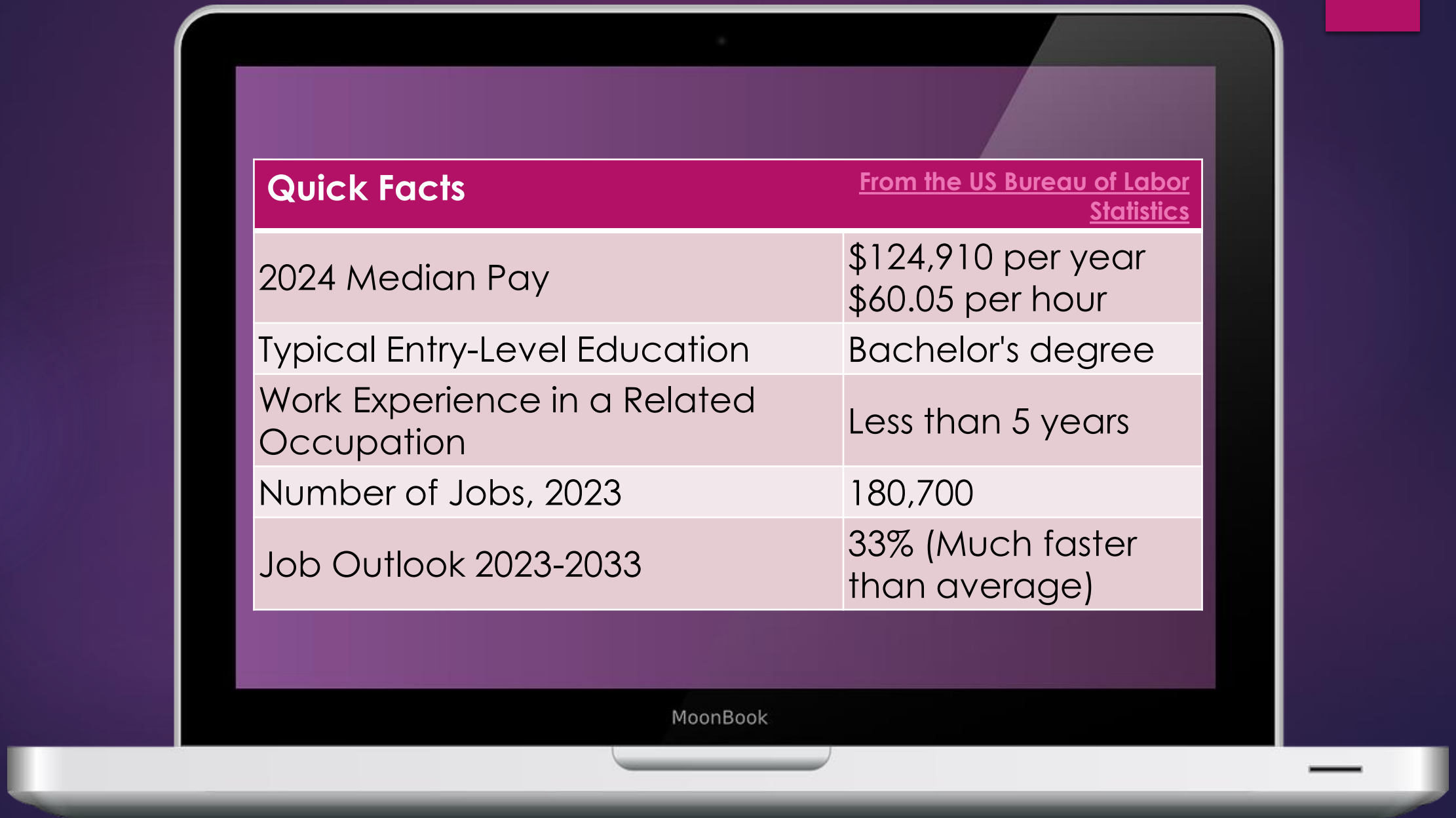
- "Think outside the box"
- Teamwork
- Communication – especially with non-technical people




## Certifications

- Certified Ethical Hacker (CEH)
- Offensive Security Certified Professional (OSCP)
- Security+
- PenTest+

# FIELD OUTLOOK AND CAREER OPPORTUNITIES




| Quick Facts | From the US Bureau of Labor Statistics |
|---|---|
| 2024 Median Pay | $124,910 per year<br>$60.05 per hour |
| Typical Entry-Level Education | Bachelor's degree |
| Work Experience in a Related Occupation | Less than 5 years |
| Number of Jobs, 2023 | 180,700 |
| Job Outlook 2023-2033 | 33% (Much faster than average) |

# WHY I WANT TO BE A PENETRATION TESTER

## PROBLEM SOLVING

- My favorite part of my current job is problem solving
- I like to know why something works, and what makes it *not* work
- Penetration testing is about going looking for problems (or potential problems) and finding solutions

## DO SOME GOOD

- My current job offers very little to the world
- I want to do something helpful or worthwhile – something for the greater good
- If I can be responsible for someone's information staying secure, I will gladly do so

## FLEXIBILITY

- Many pen testers can work partially or fully remotely
- This allows them to potentially work for employers some distance away, providing more flexibility than other fields
- I want to remain in my hometown, but earn enough to give my daughter a good life

# CONCLUSION


A penetration tester's job is to find and expose potential security threats in a network or program, then report their findings
It is a vital, growing specialty, with great opportunities, and flexibility
"Every day, companies of all sizes undergo digital transformation, designing their business processes around electronic systems…More than ever, penetration testing is needed to find vulnerabilities before internet attackers exploit them." - Leaman Crews with EC Council
This career – and the opportunities it affords – align well with my goals, personal values, and what satisfaction I hope to find in a career.